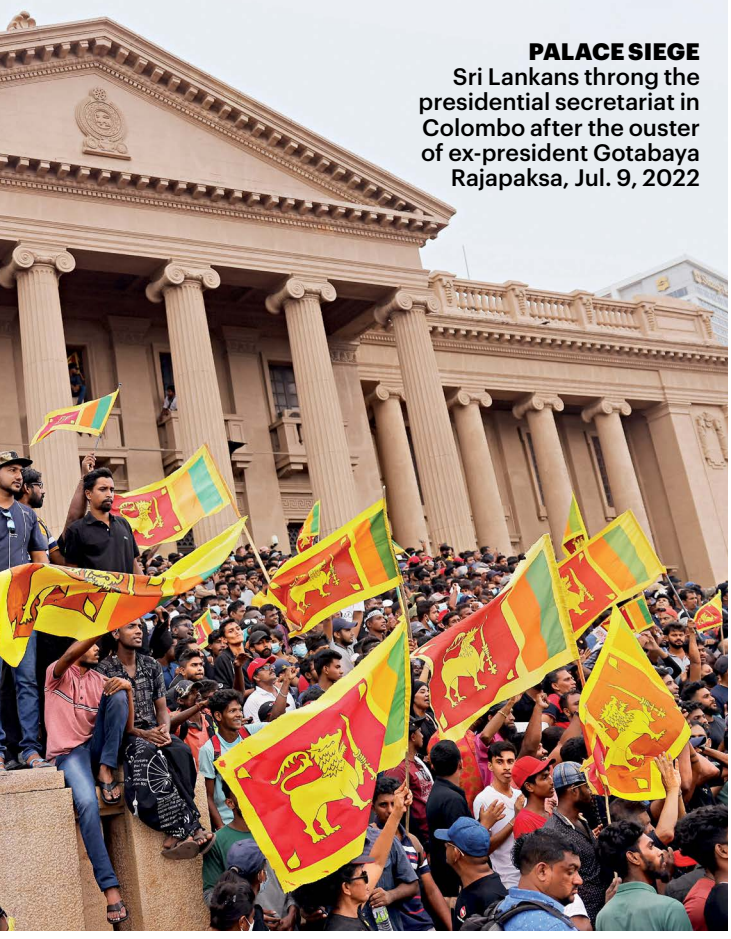


PALACE SIEGE
Sri Lankans throng the presidential secretariat in Colombo after the ouster of ex-president Gotabaya Rajapaksa, Jul. 9, 2022

REUTERS

Q. How stable are the respective coalitions you have formed to contest the election and what efforts are being made to bridge the North-South divide in Sri Lanka?

WICKREMESINGHE: Look, we had to get together two years ago because of the emergency situation that we faced. No one was trying to get together for the election. The whole party system had broken down and, as I said, people are not willing to take responsibility. One part of the SLPP (Sri Lanka Podujana Peramuna) with former president Mahinda Rajapaksa has gone its own way, but a large number of members decided that we stay together. For the first time, we are getting elements of all parties getting together. That's something we certainly must build on. We have support from many of the main parties in the south and support from many of the Tamils and the Muslims in the north. We only don't have the support of those who ran away from the 2022 battle. Let me tell you, there are no religious issues or ethnic issues in this contest. It's all economic.

"WE HOPE THE VISION STATEMENT PM MODI AND I ISSUED WILL BE IMPLEMENTED. I WANT TO PUT OUR ECONOMIC RELATIONS WITH INDIA ON A VERY STABLE FOOTING"

—WICKREMESINGHE

"THE ONE NATION THAT GAVE LANKA THE BIGGEST SUPPORT DURING ITS CRISIS WAS INDIA. STRONG TIES WITH INDIA IS A SPRINGBOARD TO JUMPSTART OUR ECONOMIC GROWTH"

—PREMADASA

PREMADASA: We formed the biggest political alliance in the country. We are the only option for the country because we promote Sri Lankanism; we have no ethnic, religious biases. We have united all the nine provinces. We have united all 25 administrative districts, including their divisions, the cities, towns and villages.

Q. Will the entry of SLPP's Namal Rajapaksa, the son of former prime minister Mahinda Rajapaksa, into the fray, have an impact on the outcome?

WICKREMESINGHE: He (Mahinda Rajapaksa) gave us support at the most difficult moments. I thanked him for that, but I can't hold him to support me during the election. He's from one party and I am from another. I think a lot of the SLPP supporters will vote for me, like many UNP (United National Party) supporters will do too.

PREMADASA: My contest is not with my rivals. All my energies have been channeled to formulate what is best for the country. My challenge is to make sure that the suffering of the Sri Lankan people is alleviated, and I am confident that my team and I will be able to do so within a time-bound target.

Q. How do you see India-Sri Lanka relations now and in the future?

WICKREMESINGHE: They are good. And we hope the vision statement that Prime Minister Modi and I issued will be implemented. I really want to put our economic relations with India on a very, very stable footing.

PREMADASA: We as a country should engage with all the nations that provide us with competitive advantages. That's the simple mantra. But in our relations, we must duly recognise that we have a special relationship with India that has to be prioritised and protected. The one country that provided us with the biggest support when Sri Lanka was in crisis was India. We appreciate that. So, we consider a strong relationship with India as a great opportunity and as a springboard for Sri Lanka to jumpstart our fast-track movement to economic growth. ■